How to Change a Car Tire

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The goal of these instructions is to learn how to change a car tire. Some car knowledge can help with these instructions, but visuals for those who aren't familiar with cars will be provided. This procedure can take around 15 to 45 minutes depending on how experienced a person is.

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- Raise Vehicle
- Remove Lug Nuts
- Remove Flat Tire
- Mount Spare Tire
- Tightening Lug Nuts
- Lower Vehicle
- Finish Tightening Lug Nuts

Equipment

- Spare tire
- Vehicle Jack

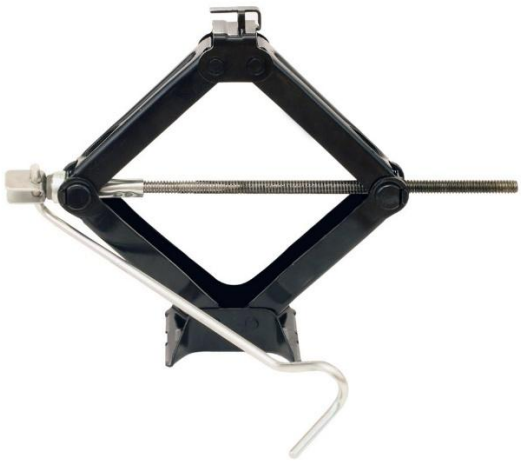

FIGURE 1: Vehicle Jack from ACCC product safety

- Lug Wrench

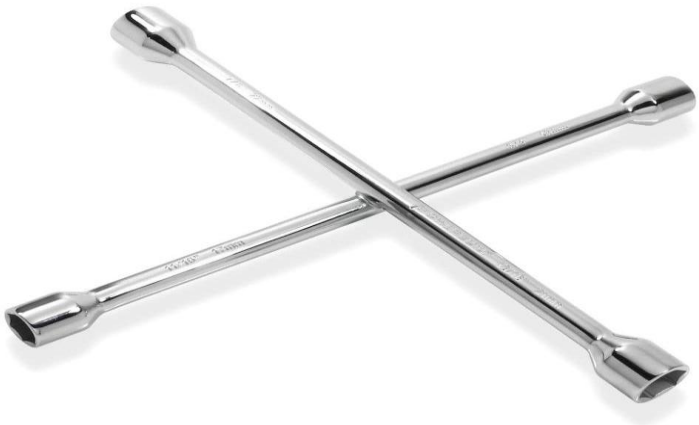

FIGURE 2: 14 INCH LUG WRENCH FROM The Home Depot

Warning

To avoid potential injury or damage, make sure to:

- Change on flat/level ground
- Keep hazard lights on
- Engage parking brake
- Use car jack on solid ground
- Never put any part of your body under the vehicle when it is being held up by only the car jack.

Step 1: Loosen Lug Nuts

- Use the lug wrench to unscrew each nut counter-clockwise for about half a turn while the tire is still on the ground.

Figure 3: Lug Wrench on Lug Nut (Image from Wikipedia)

Step 2: Place Vehicle Jack

- Place the vehicle jack under the frame of the vehicle as shown below.

FIGURE 4: VEHICLE JACK PLACED ON FRAME (IMAGE FROM Holts)

Step 3: Raise Vehicle

- Crank the jack until the damaged tire is about 7 inches above the ground.

Step 4: Remove Lug Nuts

- Fully unscrew all of the lug nuts by continuing to turn the lug wrench counter-clockwise.

Step 5: Remove Flat Tire

- Carefully pull the tire straight towards yourself to remove the damaged tire.

Step 6: Mount Spare Tire

- Grab the spare tire and align it with the tire's rim
- Once aligned with where the wheel bolts are, push spare tire onto the hub until it sits.

Step 7: Tighten Lug Nuts

- Put the lug nuts back on
- Make sure to hand-tighten lug nuts as much as possible

Step 8: Lower Vehicle

- Carefully lower the tire using the jack

Step 9: Finish Tightening Lug Nuts

- Once spare tire is touching the ground, fully tighten lug nuts in a star pattern

FIGURE 5: STAR PATTERN FOR DIFFERENT WHEEL TYPES (IMAGE FROM TPG Solutions, LLC)

- After the lug nuts are fully tightened, fully lower the vehicle and remove the jack from under the frame.

Now your spare tire should be ready to go! If your damaged tire won’t budge or come off when trying to remove, use a rubber mallet or a similar tool to tap the tire free. Make sure to stay under high speeds with a spare tire on, as spare tires aren’t meant for high speeds or long distances. If possible, re-tighten the lug nuts after a couple of miles to make sure that they are secure.